

AND THEN there were...

It may have been Rahul Gandhi's year but other politicians, businessmen, actors, performers and sportsmen ensured it was a roller-coaster till the very end



P. Chidambaram National GUARD

CHIDAMBARAM HAS FORCED India's notoriously turf-sensitive intelligence agencies to share inputs on a daily basis.

Palaniappan Chidambaram's appointment as home minister is both a triumph and tragedy. A triumph because it shows how one man can set things right in a ministry notorious for being practically asleep while the country was under attack. A tragedy because it shows how major institutions in India continue to be personality driven. The home minister is one of the most powerful in the Cabinet and has under him not only the eyes and ears of the state—the Intelligence Bureau and the CBI—but also nearly the half-million strong Central paramilitary forces, among the world's largest. This didn't count for much under the previous incumbent, Shivraj Patil, whom Chidambaram replaced after the 26/11 attacks. In little over a year at the helm, he has energised the ministry—from making officials report to work on time to prioritising a Central response to the festering Maoist insurrection in the heartland and achieving what was deemed to be near-impossible: getting the multiple intelligence agencies to sit and share intelligence at the Multi Agency Centre. It was clear that his tenure was not going to be business as usual. The carrot and stick policy against the Naxalites—come to the negotiating table or face consequences—is yet to deliver results but is the first response from a ministry which looked the other way as the red army trained, mobilised and killed security forces with impunity. Chidambaram's most ambitious proposal is nothing short of a complete refocussing of the ministry to tackle internal security and the creation of a forward-looking National Counter Terrorism Centre. This body will have intelligence, investigations and operations wings and a broad mandate to prevent, contain and respond to all forms of terrorism. The MP from Sivaganga has been faulted for being brusque and abrasive, but Chidambaram's biggest achievement was in instilling confidence in the nation that another attack would not happen and if it did, there would be serious consequences for its backers. A year after 26/11, India has not seen a significant terror strike, an achievement he can justifiably take credit for.

by Sandeep Unnithan